

all states, including those in the South that had taken up arms to defend slavery.

The easy part proved to be getting the amendment through the Senate, whose Republican majority ensured its smooth passage on April 8, 1864. The House of Representatives proved more recalcitrant, however, and the measure failed to get the necessary two-thirds majority by 13 votes.

Its fate then became a leading issue in the 1864 presidential election campaign, with the Republicans eagerly adopting the cause as a central plank of their platform. The Democrats denounced the amendment as “unwise, impolitic, cruel, and unworthy of the support of a civilized people.” Lincoln’s re-election in November 1864 effectively settled the debate between the two parties. But instead of choosing to wait for the sitting of the Republican-dominated 39th Congress in March 1865, the president used his annual message to Congress on December 6, 1864, to introduce the measure.

Cheers in the House

Lincoln preferred to solicit the support of dissenting Democrats in the lame-duck 38th Congress, wanting to make its passage a bipartisan measure. With some arm-twisting, the necessary backing was obtained; on January 31, 1865, the amendment passed the House with two votes to spare. The news was greeted with wild rejoicing in Congress itself and by a 100-gun salute in Washington, D.C. It was fitting that among those celebrating inside the House were Black Americans, who had been admitted to the public galleries for the first time the previous year. George W. Julian, a Republican congressman, noted, “I have felt, ever since the vote, as if I were in a new country.”

Unlike the struggle in the House of Representatives, ratification itself proved relatively straightforward. Most Northern states quickly fell into line, and as the Civil War came to an end it was made known to former Confederate states that acceptance was a precondition for full re-admission into the Union. The necessary